

Colossal Cave 3D: A Retrospective on the Adventure Game Genre in VR

To my great excitement, Colossal Cave Adventure 3D was released the day after I bought an Oculus Quest 2.

One of my most treasured game experiences is receiving King's Quest VI for Christmas in 1993. I'd played the earlier games at a friend's house (whose dad was a mathematician and knew about computers) and was already mesmerized by the concept of exploring a strange kingdom. Unlike Mario, Ninja Turtles, and R-Type—which I also liked—King's Quest wasn't twitchy, it was tranquil. I'd go home and draw out my own map screens on sheets of paper. But KQ6 took the genre to the next level, with a regal VGA colour palette, crisp controls and sounds, and a complex story tree that broke beyond simple fairytale tropes.

I became a Sierra acolyte. The tragic rise and fall of the company is well-known. King's Quest 7 for Windows 95 was cool, but buggy; and King's Quest 8, during Sierra's final, 3D era, was a disaster.

1993 was the zenith the point-and-click adventure. Whether the subsequent decline of the genre was tied to the unfortunate demise of Sierra, or the inevitable consequence of the rise of the Internet and ready spoiler access, is hard to say. Sierra had always positioned its adventure games at the cutting edge of technology, and somewhere along the line, the aesthetic ceased to be charming. The adventure game had wandered into the uncanny valley.

I hope this sets the stage for my great interest in Colossal Cave Adventure 3D, 30 years later.

After losing Sierra due to the abuses of a deceptive businessman (detailed in Ken Williams' book, *Not All Fairy Tales Have Happy Endings*) Ken and Roberta sailed the world on their boat. Roberta had given up on game design, turning to historical fiction instead. This is until Ken wrote the book, and then began tinkering in Unity, when Roberta couldn't help but look over his shoulder.

The Williams' first game in 30 years isn't an original, but a remake, of the first adventure game from 1975, "Adventure" by Will Crowther. The Williams' have rebooted the Adventure genre to a time before King's Quest or Mystery House, restoring its primal iteration. Just as that game was made at a nascent stage of its medium (computer games as such) this one translates it into a nascent stage of a new medium—Virtual Reality. Could something essential be recovered in the process?

In the hours I spent fooling around with VR before *Colossal Cave* was released, I did some poking around with whichever free games and demos I could find (the Quest store appears to have removed the filter that allows you to sort by free), and developed some strong first impressions.

People assume VR is a continuation of PC gaming, but it's a radical break. PC games can be complex without being overstimulating. VR overwhelms the perceptual apparatus after a short amount of time. The heaviness of the headset, motion sickness and cognitive-optical effects are a part of it, but it's also the degree of media saturation. The metaverse is like existing in a slightly blurry medium-res Silver City world. Everything is bright, and busy, and smiley, and cartoony, and monetized. After 20 minutes you're feeling a bit barfy, and grateful for your real-reality, which suddenly appears to have great graphics.

This said, these negatives are balanced against positives. The ability of the medium to depict depth is just cool. I frequently find myself wanting to dive into another dimension for 10 or 15 minutes. I was telling a friend that, contrary to expectations, VR is less like a TV, and more like a swimming pool.

I knew I liked *Colossal Cave* from the first minute I played it. It opens "at the end of a road before a small brick building. Around you is a forest. A small stream flows out of the building and down a gully." Some string music plays. It's simple, clean, and bright. There's even a recommendation for an atypical approach to motion control, favoured by Roberta Williams.

I felt like I was in the hands of an experienced, conscientious game designer, who didn't confuse dazzle with satisfaction.

So for me, the game was a win simply as a tech demo for a much-needed chill, explorative approach to VR.

But what about as a game? Is *Colossal Cave Adventure* *fun*?

Somewhere in my spelunking, I started to lose faith. I started to wonder about the reasoning—and the sense—in porting this particular text adventure to VR. If Mario64 had been entirely underground it would have been a gloomy, claustrophobic entry to the N64. In most adventure games, you pick up a few items, mentally index the map, and solve some puzzles as you break through to new areas. In *Colossal Cave*, I couldn't solve a single puzzle, and the cave, and mental indexing, just kept going and going.

When I finally found my way out of one long nondescript maze of tunnels, and then fell into another maze of identical corridors, I almost wondered if the remake itself was meant to be understood as a critique of VR itself as a long, dark, empty maze.

There's something a bit dead about it. Not enough other characters, or enough interaction. Maybe this is appropriate to a text-based adventure where one doesn't want to complicate things, but in a VR world, it's lonely walking around all by yourself. The gameplay of those *Mario Galaxy* games is incredible, but they also felt very *Little Prince*.

But the game's biggest flaw is its pace—walking speed. The original has a sort of fast travel in that if you know your way around you can blaze from one end of the map to another with 10 keystrokes. Going from one end of the map to another in VR, and then up to the wellhouse and back takes ages, even with the magic phrases. I also often found myself getting stuck in the game's geometry and having to reset.

I started having more fun when I realized that referencing the map the game provides is essential, and also when I gave in and started looking up some spoilers. Some of the puzzles are pure moon logic. Like being unable to pick up a bird because it's inexplicably afraid of the starred iron rod in our inventory. In a contemporary adventure game, we'd expect some subtle cues to point us in the right direction. More significantly, I hadn't even gotten the memo that the purpose of the game was to recover 15 treasures from the cave back to the brick building.

Once I loosened up and the expansive map started to come into better mental focus for me, and I started to have more fun. It's not all tunnels and mazes, there's lots of cool vistas and other visual setpieces. This is around the time I appreciated the second major achievement of *Colossal Cave*. It's an incredible museum piece—a testament to the greatness of the original game.

I'd played with the original when I heard this was coming out, and dismissed it as an antique. It's only as I started to get the hang of the game that I realized many of its brilliant nuances. The sheer variety of kinds of puzzles packed into one text-based game is astounding. Subtle, silly things. A precious vase you pick up shatters wherever you would set it down, so you need to place it on a rare pillow to save it. Sensible enough, but what's so unusual about this puzzle is that only a handful of items have environmental properties (such as shattering), so your brain isn't automatically syllogizing this item against that, deducing every possible outcome, because the parameters of the game aren't so determined. You kind of have to get a spark. You remember the spark? The game is filled with quirky little loose ends like this. Some of

them are tedious, or moon logic, but there's a refreshing diversity of connections at play. I still find myself wanting to go back for more.

This appreciation helped me wonder at the amount of atmosphere and complexity the original built out of *plain text* derived from 700 lines of code. For me, it evoked the weirdness of the fact that text, phrased a certain way, manifests as a sophisticated *game*. Crowthers said that the natural language input system gave users the illusion of control. It was cool to realize the 'logos' of so many of my favourite games was so simple, or rather, so fundamental. King's Quest VI could've been written 2500 years ago!

I count *Colossal Cave* as a qualified success—as a tech demo and as a museum piece—at a nascent stage of VR, in which qualified successes may be as good as it gets. I hope the Williams' continue to make classic-style adventure games and continue to elevate the genre.